ABSENCE MANAGEMENT — PATTERN BLIND

WE'D MANAGED EVERY ABSENCE. WE'D NEVER LOOKED AT THEM TOGETHER.

The data was in the system. We weren't reading it right. Here's what we found when we did.

WHY ABSENCE STAYS REACTIVE

Most operations manage absence case by case — return-to-work interview, trigger point, reset. **That's correct process.** It's also blind to the pattern sitting underneath it.

WHAT CASE-BY-CASE MANAGEMENT MISSES

- Who's actually driving the frequency, versus total days
- Whether absence clusters on specific days of the week
- Which shifts or teams carry disproportionate volume
- Whether short frequent absences are costing more than long ones

We had an operator with fourteen absences in twelve months. We'd managed every one of them. We'd never once looked at the fourteen together — until a pattern review made it impossible to miss.

THREE ADDITIONS. SAME PROCESS. BETTER VISIBILITY.

01 Monthly pattern review across the team

Instances by person, not just total days. Frequency tells you who's driving volume. Days tells you severity. You need both numbers in the same view.

FREQUENCY VISIBLE FOR THE FIRST TIME

02 Day-of-week mapping

Monday and Friday concentration isn't evidence of anything on its own. But it's a question — and questions are where conversations start. Map the data before you draw conclusions.

PATTERN BEFORE JUDGEMENT

03 Bradford Factor scores shared openly

When people understand the formula and see their own score, the conversation changes. Transparency doesn't fix the problem — it removes the surprise when it surfaces.

TRANSPARENCY SHIFTS BEHAVIOUR

ABSENCE INSTANCES BY DAY OF WEEK

Illustrative — team aggregate over 12 months

Monday + Friday = 55% of all instances.

The conversation that followed wasn't about those days. It was about what sits either side of rest days — and whether shift allocation was contributing to the pattern.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU

YOU CAN MANAGE EVERY ABSENCE AND NEVER MANAGE ABSENCE.

Managing instances is process compliance. Managing patterns is operations. Both matter — but only one of them tells you what's actually happening.

When did you last look at your absence data as a pattern rather than a case list?

Full breakdown → OperationsEdge.co.uk